

Volunteer Notes for the Harbourside Lifeboat Museum

The Harbourside Lifeboat Museum occupies the old boathouse at the end of the east pier and is run entirely by volunteers. These notes are for anyone taking a shift on the door, in the boat hall or in the workshop, and they assume no knowledge of boats, of museums or of the sea. Everything a volunteer needs in order to open the building, look after its visitors and close it again is written here, and where it is not, the person to ask is named.

The museum exists because the station moved to the new slipway in 1994 and the town declined to let the boathouse be sold. The building had housed a lifeboat since 1867, and the crew lists on the wall inside the door run without a gap from that year to the last launch. A trust was formed, the council granted a lease, and the first volunteers opened the doors the following summer with a single boat, a borrowed till and a hand-lettered sign. Most of what is described in these notes grew out of that first season.

A word on why any of this matters. The museum is not a collection of old boats; it is the record of a town that put its own people to sea in bad weather for a century and a quarter, and of the families who watched them go. Visitors who arrive for the boats usually leave talking about the crew lists, the photographs and the letters, and the volunteers who do the job best are the ones who understand that they are looking after a story as much as a building, and that the story is not finished.

There are three boats on display and one in the workshop. The oldest is a pulling and sailing boat of 1902, restored over eleven winters; the largest is the motor lifeboat that served here from 1951 to 1978; the smallest is an inshore inflatable that most visitors recognise at once. The boat in the workshop is a private restoration on loan, and the owner works on it on Thursdays. Visitors may watch from the rail but may not enter the workshop, however friendly the invitation sounds.

Opening up takes two people and about twenty minutes. One unlocks the side door, disarms the alarm within the sixty seconds it allows, and switches on the hall lights from the panel by the stairs. The other walks the boat hall with the checklist, looking for anything that has moved, dripped or been left behind, and initials the sheet on the office door. The front doors are opened last, at ten exactly, because there is nearly always somebody waiting and it is better that they see a building that is ready for them.

The till is counted at opening and at closing and the float is kept at forty pounds in coin. Card payments go through the reader on the counter, which needs the office wifi and occasionally needs the office wifi turned off and on again. Takings are bagged, labelled with the date and both volunteers' initials, and locked in the safe; nobody carries cash home. The bank run is done on Mondays by whichever trustee is on the rota, and the rota is pinned on the office wall beside the safe.

Admission is free and donations are invited, which means the collecting box by the door matters more than the shop. It is emptied weekly, counted by two people, and the total is written on the whiteboard in the office where every volunteer can see it. A month in which the box does badly is

usually a month in which the door has not been staffed, and the whiteboard is there so that the connection is visible to everyone rather than only to the treasurer at the year end.

Radios, keys and the first-aid kit live in the office. The keys never leave the building except in the hands of a keyholder, whose names are on the list by the safe. The first-aid kit is checked monthly and the check is signed for on the lid, and the accident book beside it is filled in for every incident, however small it seemed at the time. The radios are charged overnight on the shelf above the desk, and a volunteer on the pier or the platform carries one switched on; the base set in the office is answered by whoever is nearest.

The boat hall is the heart of the museum and the place where most of a shift is spent. Visitors are free to walk around all three boats and to climb the viewing platform beside the motor lifeboat, and they may touch the hull of the inshore boat, which is there for that purpose. They may not board any boat, lean on the pulling boat's oars, or lift children onto the platforms, and the volunteer on the hall is expected to say so kindly and early rather than firmly and late.

The photographs along the north wall are copies and may be pointed at, photographed and, within reason, touched. The originals are in the archive upstairs, which is not open to the public, and requests to see them are passed to the archivist by email rather than promised on the spot. The letters in the glass case are originals and the case is locked; the key is in the office and is not lent to visitors under any circumstances, including descendants of the writers.

The audio guide is a set of handsets on the counter and it is free. It is also fragile, elderly and unloved by its own manufacturer, so handsets are issued one per adult, signed out in the book, and checked back in. A handset that does not come back is written up in the incident book the same day; one that comes back broken goes in the box marked for repair with a note saying what happened, and nobody attempts to mend it with tape, however tempting the roll on the bench looks.

Questions from visitors are the best part of the job and also the part most likely to go wrong. Answer what you know, say plainly when you do not, and offer to find out; there is a card of the commonest questions and their answers by the till. Do not guess at dates, names or the circumstances of a rescue, because visitors frequently know more than they let on, and a confident wrong answer travels further than a hesitant right one ever will, usually by way of the harbour cafe.

Dogs are welcome on a lead, pushchairs are welcome everywhere except the platform, and wheelchair users can reach everything on the ground floor by the ramp at the side door, which a volunteer opens on request. The lift to the archive is for staff and researchers only. If a visitor needs it for access to the meeting room, a keyholder operates it and stays with the visitor for the whole of the trip up and the whole of the trip down, without exception.

At the end of a hall shift, walk the room once more with the checklist, replace any handset left on a bench, straighten the rope barriers, and note on the sheet anything that will need attention: a loose board on the platform, a light out, a smell of damp in the corner by the slipway doors. Small things written down get fixed on Thursday; small things remembered get forgotten by Friday and found by a visitor on Saturday morning.

The workshop is a working space and is treated as one. Anyone entering it wears the shoes they arrived in and none of the sandals kept for the summer, keeps hair and scarves tied back near the lathe, and asks before touching any tool that is not their own. The Thursday crew are all volunteers too, and they are generous with their time when asked and short with it when a visitor wanders in past the rail with a coffee. The rail is there for a reason, and the reason is the lathe.

Conservation of the boats follows one principle: do as little as will keep them sound, and record everything. Paint is renewed only where it has failed, timber is replaced only where it is rotten, and every replacement is dated and initialled on the inside face where a future restorer will find it. The 1902 boat still has more than half of its original planking because eleven winters of volunteers resisted the temptation to make it look new.

Materials are bought from the suppliers on the list in the workshop and from nowhere else, because the list is the result of twenty years of finding out which linseed oil goes off, which bronze fastenings are actually brass, and which timber merchant will still cut a plank to a pattern. Receipts go in the tin on the bench and are reconciled monthly by the treasurer, who would rather see too many receipts than too few.

The motor lifeboat's engine is run once a month, on the first Thursday, for fifteen minutes, with the hall doors open and a volunteer on the pier to wave visitors back from the exhaust. It is not run for visitors on request, however far they have come, because a cold engine started twice in a day is an engine that will one day not start at all. The run is logged, with the oil pressure and the time it took to fire.

Tools are the museum's, not the volunteers', and they go back on the shadow board at the end of every session. A gap on the board at closing time is searched for until it is filled, and a tool that has genuinely gone missing is written in the incident book. Volunteers who prefer their own tools are welcome to bring them and are asked to mark them, because a marked tool comes back and an unmarked one becomes the museum's by the end of the month.

Hazardous materials, which here means paint, thinners, oil and the two-stroke mix for the inshore boat, live in the yellow cabinet by the slipway doors and nowhere else. The cabinet is locked at closing, the key is on the keyholder's ring, and the inventory taped inside the door is updated whenever anything goes in or out. The fire brigade inspected the arrangement in the spring and asked that it stay exactly as it is.

The shop is small, sells things that have something to do with the sea or the station, and exists to make a modest surplus rather than to compete with the harbour gift shops. Stock is counted at the end of each month, prices are on the shelf edge and not on the item, and anything that has not sold in a year is offered to volunteers at cost and then given away. Sentiment about stock is discouraged; sentiment about the boats is what the building is for.

Books are the exception. The museum publishes its own short history and a booklet of the crew lists, sells them at a price that covers the printing, and keeps them in stock permanently; a visitor who has come a long way for a family connection should never be told that the booklet with the

name in it has sold out. Reprints are ordered when the shelf is down to twenty copies, by the trustee who looks after the shop.

Events are held in the boat hall out of hours, are booked through the trustees, and follow a rule that nothing is served or done that could mark, dampen or dent a boat. Candles are refused, red wine is refused, and dancing is confined to the space by the doors. The rope barriers stay up. A hirer who wants an exception is politely told that the boats were here first and will be here after, and that has so far ended every argument.

The lifeboat day in August is the busiest day of the year and needs every volunteer the museum has. The building opens an hour early, the shop is staffed by two, the door by two, the hall by three, and the workshop is closed to visitors so that the Thursday crew can run the engine at noon for the crowd. The day is planned at the July meeting and the plan is printed and pinned in the office by the end of that week.

Photography by visitors is encouraged, and the only request is that flash is not used on the letters in the case. Filming for broadcast, or by anyone with a tripod and a crew, is arranged through the trustees, is charged for, and is supervised, because a camera crew left alone in a boat hall will put a light stand through a hull in the time it takes to find a plug socket. That is not a hypothetical example.

Complaints are rare and are taken seriously. A visitor with a complaint is listened to, thanked, and given the card with the chair's email address; the volunteer does not argue, does not apologise for things that were not wrong, and writes the complaint in the book the same day with the facts and no commentary. The trustees read the book at every meeting and answer every complaint in writing.

Closing is the reverse of opening and takes longer, because visitors linger and volunteers are tired. The front doors are closed at five, the hall is walked and the checklist signed, the till is counted and bagged, the shop shutter is pulled down, and the lights are switched off from the panel in the order printed beside it. The alarm is set last, by the side door, and the person setting it waits outside until the confirming beep.

The building is old, timber and very close to the sea, and it is checked for water after every storm by whichever keyholder lives nearest. The places that leak are known and are listed on the card by the office door; new leaks are added to the card and reported to the trustee who looks after the building. Buckets are kept under the stairs for the purpose and are emptied, not left to fill.

Volunteers sign in and out on the sheet by the office door, both for the insurance and so that a keyholder locking up knows the building is empty. New volunteers do their first three shifts alongside an experienced one and are then given the notes, a key if they want one, and a shift of their own. Anyone who has not volunteered for a year is asked, kindly, whether they wish to remain on the list.

The museum closes for January and half of February. The boats are covered, the heating is turned to frost protection, the shop is stocktaken and the building is deep-cleaned by a team of volunteers on

the first Saturday of the closure, which is also the day the annual meeting is held in the boat hall with the covers on and everyone in coats. The meeting is short by tradition and long by practice.

The chair writes a one-page account of the year: how many visitors came, how much was raised, what was spent on the boats, what went wrong and what is planned. It is read at the town meeting in March and pinned in the office afterwards. Volunteers are named in it only with their permission, which most give and some, for reasons of their own, do not, and both choices are respected without comment.

Lastly, these notes are revised every winter by whoever has done the most shifts, and each version is dated and kept in the office file. A rule that nobody can explain is dropped at the revision; a rule that somebody can explain is kept even if nobody likes it. Most of the rules here were paid for by a broken handset, a flooded workshop or a cross visitor, and the notes are shorter than the list of those.